



Security Watch

Code Piggybacks On .xls Files

Problem

In the middle of August, Microsoft released a security bulletin patching an important problem in Microsoft Excel. The problem affects MS Excel 2000, MS Excel XP, MS Excel 2003 on PCs and Excel 2004 for Mac machines.

The vulnerability does not effect MS Excel 2007.

The problem can occur from .xls files downloaded from Web sites or from e-mail attachments. A maliciously written Excel document can corrupt the memory used for the Excel workspace, and execute code remotely on the computer. This problem is even more acute when opening Excel documents as a system administrator.

This problem is flagged as being critical for MS Excel 2000. Systems that work with Excel files are at risk, but servers with access to the Internet are more vulnerable. Any malicious activity using this method relies on some kind of action from the user, either opening the file voluntarily or being misled to do so. Any attacker would have the same amount of control over the system as the user.

Solution

Microsoft has released a patch covering this security hole which is available at <http://tinyurl.com/5j4ay7>. Before installing the update it is essential that all the service packs for the relevant windows OS is installed. It is always safer to work without administrative privileges while working with downloaded documents.

electromagnetic field so generated is picked up by the device antenna, which in turn powers up the gadget to be charged.

Apart from laptops and mobiles, this technology can also be used to power refrigerators, lamps and televisions.

Researchers are also looking into the uses of micro-robots that can be used to build shape-shifting devices. Developed by researchers at Carnegie Mellon University, these robots can be designed to form large-scale machines. They can be programmed from many different devices. The chipmaker also demonstrated its work on the next generation of robots.

Intel displayed technology that gives robots the sense of touch.

The second robot demonstrated technology that enabled it to recognise faces as well as interpret and execute generic commands with state-of-the-art motion planning, manipulations, perception and artificial intelligence.

AN OPEN SOURCE TRACKER

Lost Your Laptop? Here's Help

Computer scientists at the University of Washington have developed the first free, open source laptop tracking system. What's more, users themselves without the need to call on any external corporate body can install the system.

The system has been called Adeona, after the Roman goddess of safe returns.

On the cards is a version of the tracking system for

the iPhone. The developers of Adeona say that the danger with commercial laptop tracking systems is that it is not possible to know if someone at the tracking company wouldn't exploit the company's possession of personal information.

Information about data residing on the laptop is also vulnerable to exploitation. Further, courts can also call upon such data in a subpoena.

A user has to install a piece of free software on the laptop. The credential key that the software provides can reside on a thumb drive. The key is required to track the laptop if it's stolen.

The software uses several different methods for laptop tracking.

It can broadcast the IP address where the computer is used. It directs the inbuilt camera (present in a few laptops) to take pictures every half a minute of the person using the stolen device.

DELL INTRODUCES NEW LINE

Cheaper Laptops For India And China

Dell's market strategy was focussed on selling products of the same quality worldwide. In a major divergence from this long standing strategy, Dell introduced two notebooks and two desktops manufactured and priced for developing economies like India, China and Brazil. The devices are targeted specifically at small businessmen, and hope to exploit a rapidly



expanding Asian, African and Latin-American market.

This follows the strategies of Dell's chief competitors, Lenovo, Hewlett-Packard and Acer—all of whom have similar strategies for harvesting profits out of the same market space.

Dell posted huge profits in the first quarter of this year, with five times as much as the profits coming from the BRIC nations (Brazil, Russia, India and China) than in its home country, the United States. Dell's biggest strength that worked well in the Trans-Atlantic Nations, turned out to be its biggest weakness in the developing economies. Their direct model of sales had customers order their computers over the phone and the Internet, but this business model turned out to be unsuitable for the vast rural markets waiting to expand in China and India. Retailers in China are already stocking Dell machines, which is not done anywhere else in the world as yet. There are 2,700 Dell outlets shared between the Suning and Gome retailers. This option seems to be feasible for countries like India too.

The new Vostro notebooks are being sold for Rs 20,750 and the new desktop PCs are being sold for